Modals

Must



Expressing

- strong obligation
- logical conclusion
- certainty

Example

- You must stop when the traffic lights turn red.
- He must be very tired. He's been working all day long.



Must not



Expressing

- prohibition

Example

- You must not smoke in the hospital.

Can



Expressing

- ability
- permission
- possibility

Example

- I can swim.
- Can I use your phone please?
- Smoking can cause cancer.



Could

Expressing

- ability in the past
- polite permission
- possibility

Example

- When I was young I could run fast.
- Excuse me, could I just say something?
- It could rain tomorrow!





May



Expressing

- permission
- possibility / probability

Example

- May I come in?
- Where are my keys? They may be in the car.



Might

Expressing

- polite permission
- possibility / probability

Example

- Might I suggest an idea?
- I might go on holiday to Australia next year.





Need not

Expressing

- lack of necessity/ absence of obligation



Example

- I need not buy tomatoes. There are plenty of tomatoes in the fridge.

Should/ought to

Expressing

- 50 % obligation
- advice
- logical conclusion



Example

- I should / ought to see a doctor. I have a terrible headache.
- You should / ought to revise your lessons
- He should / ought to be very tired. He's been working all day long.





9th English Unit 4 PR PO Supple Pages 088-116.indd 98 28-11-2022 17:27:20